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Who takes part in film tourism? The analysis of determinants of visiting film locations

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Abstract

Film tourism is one of the fastest developing sub-segments of creative tourism in the 21st century. Many studies investigated tourists' motivation and behavior towards film tourism in the context of psychological and emotional motives and their involvement and experience. However, we still know very little about the structure of visitors of film sites. Utilizing primary data collected in Slovakia and adopting the econometric approach, the aim of this empirical study is to estimate the relationship between preferred trip parameters and the decision to include a visit to a film location in the travel plan. The results suggest that visits to film sites occur to a significant extent by chance, film tourism is additional, mainly to other segments of tourism, characterized as adventurous and explorative experiences. Visits to film locations occur mainly as trips by younger age groups and longer stays, mostly as self-organized trips, regardless of budget, frequency of travel, or gender.

KEYWORDS

film site, film tourism, logit, preferred type of stay, survey, V4 country

1 | INTRODUCTION

In the 21st century Europe, tourism is more strongly linked to the development of the creative sectors than in the previous eras of its evolution (Godbey, 2008; Jarábková & Hamada, 2012). Tourists are more active, adventurous and seek multi-adventure stays, utilizing the cultural and creative potential of the destination (Hartley, 2005). Not surprisingly, creative tourism, which offers tourists the opportunity to develop their own creative potential through active participation in learning about specific skills, traditions, and unique qualities of local sites (Richards & Raymond, 2000), is already a topic to which considerable attention is paid in the scientific literature (Korez-Vide, 2013; Lim, 2016; Ta & Yang, 2019).

Nevertheless, film tourism which can be classified as a subtype of creative tourism, is also receiving increasing attention in the scientific

literature (Kiráľová, 2016; Richards & Wilson, 2007). The interest in film tourism has also been triggered by the supply side due to films attracting a huge number of visitors to their destinations (Riley & Van Doren, 1992). The available sources of literature examine film tourism mainly from the perspective of its economic and multiplier effects on local economy (Tooke & Baker, 1996), perspective of destination promotion (Abdulsamie, 2016) and branding (Hudson & Ritchie, 2006), the impact of film tourism on the image of the destination (Beeton, 2005), tourists' motivation (Oviedo-García et al., 2016), tourists' experiences (Carl et al., 2007), or authenticity (Tzanelli, 2006). Our study contributes the knowledge on tourist behavior in the context of film tourism but takes a different direction from motivational studies.

First, we identify several gaps in the knowledge in the current discussion on the topic of film tourism in a behavioral context. A number

of authors propose (e.g., Domínguez-Azcue et al., 2021; Hahm & Wang, 2011; Kim, 2012) a better understanding of the segmentation of film tourism target groups, or a specification of the types of stays during which film tourism is targeted or occurs randomly. At the same time, it can be stated that the segmentation of film tourists was realized mainly on the basis of emotional factors, such as type of emotion or nostalgia (e.g., Hetland et al., 2016; Kim & Kim, 2018; Ng & Chan, 2019), what we consider to be the main limitation of current knowledge. As we still do not really know, which tourists engage in film tourism activities, we propose to explore the relationship between parameters of a trip and the decision to visit a film location. Second, there are many geographical gaps in the current list of film tourism studies. In the remits of the V4 countries, the phenomenon of film tourism is largely unexplored. The knowledge on the drivers of film tourism within the remit of post-socialistic and the central-west European transitional economy is novel to literature on the topic (Chou, 2013). The majority of empirical studies were conducted in the remit of Western Europe and the USA, Australia and New Zealand, or Asia (Domínguez-Azcue et al., 2021).

Therefore, the primary motivation of the study is to contribute to the pool of knowledge on tourist behavior by describing the trajectories of film tourists in the remit of the V4 countries, and in particular, to estimate the relationship between trip set-ups or preferences, and the decision to include a visit to a film location in the travel plan. The secondary aim of the study is to evaluate the degree of haphazardness in visiting film locations within a sample of tourists in the remit of the V4 country. By setting-up these goals, we want to achieve better understanding of the types of travel that are associated with visiting film locations and establish who is truly a film tourist. The study brings both theoretical and managerial implications for practitioners. The results of the analysis will serve mainly destination management in an effort to capitalize on film tourism as a promotional tool for increasing destination visits. To establish who truly is a “film tourist,” and what types of trips are associated with visiting film locations, is especially important for strategic planning of destination management and marketing (Gartner, 1994). The results could support a better integration of film site visits into integrated tourism products.

2 | THEORY BACKGROUND

Film tourism has received a lot of attention in tourism literature since the early 1990s (Heitmann, 2010). This branch of tourism, which falls under the umbrella of creative tourism, refers to traveling to attractions or destinations that have been featured in films, TV shows, music (Hudson & Ritchie, 2006), or otherwise related to audio-visual production (Macdonis, 2004). Literature identified many specific forms of film tourism, including mapping film localities, visiting film studios, watching the filming process, taking a thematic film tour, celebrity-spotting, visiting film festivals, visiting film award shows or events (Connell, 2012; Kim, 2012). With the growth of the audio-visual entertainment industry, the demand for visiting film sites has also grown in recent decades (Teng, 2021).

2.1 | Behavioral aspects of film tourism

Our study contributes to the theory on tourist behavior (Chen & Rahman, 2018; Kim et al., 2017; Teng, 2021), which mostly focused on tourists' motivation and behavior towards film tourism through their involvement (Fitzsimons et al., 2008). Thus, destination management and marketing can benefit from current literature in an effort to answer the question: why does a film tourist want to visit a film site? (Jang et al., 2009). The approaches recognized as drivers of film tourism are mostly psychological-emotional factors and socio-demographic factors (Araújo Vila et al., 2021; Beeton, 2010).

With regard to the psychological-emotional factors, the main motive of the tourists is to experience contact with the site in which the film was shot, especially in order to compare the site captured on film and what it looks like in reality (Kotíková, 2013). Although the set of individual motives for visiting a film destination and tourists' expectations are highly individualized (Macdonis & Sparks, 2009), the genre and specific aspects of films play a pivotal role in the formulation of tourists' motives (Raj, 2018). Beeton (2005) recognizes several categories of the main motives for traveling to film locations of psychological, or emotional character, such as re-experiencing a film, re-storytelling in a real environment, the interest to develop own imagination, the interest in seeing specific aspects of the site, which they liked in the film, or because of the connection of the site to a favorite actor. Similarly, Macdonis and Sparks (2009) believe that if a tourist chooses a holiday destination based on a film, they may be motivated by the elements of escape, romance, and fantasy.

Motivation to visit the film site has evolved in literature from 3P perspective of Macdonis (2004) to evaluation of complex push and pull factors (de Araújo et al., 2018; Oviedo-García et al., 2016; Pan & Tsang, 2014). These studies have established that self-identity, ego enhancement-related factors, fantasy, learning, novelty, prestige, and participation in fan activities can be considered as push factors, while mainly the sense of novelty, imagination of non-existing world, observation of scenery unknown in own culture can be considered as a push factors. The structure of visitors to the film site is also influenced by cultural aspects, such as the language of the film, or the relationship of the film site population to the country of origin of the film (Hoa et al., 2015).

2.2 | Planning and promotion of film tourism

Our study seeks to provide answers to the question “Who is truly a film tourist,” bearing in mind that the answer to this question is a relevant basis for the planning, management and marketing of a destination, as film tourism can have a significant impact on the improvement of a destination's image (Domínguez-Azcue et al., 2021; Gartner, 1994; Iwashita, 2003; Macdonis & Sparks, 2009; Shani et al., 2009), and thus support the competitiveness of the destination (Hudson & Ritchie, 2006). However, this may not be true in the case of films that negatively affect the viewer's cognitive and affective perception of destination as a whole, or through individual attributes of a movie

(Loureiro & de Araujo, 2015). Mostly the DMOs and local (or regional) governments have the competences and a high interest to engage and influence the development of film tourism within the destination. Film tourism planning, both in terms of management and marketing, requires to be understood correctly and sensitively to the needs and expectations of film tourists (Polianskaia et al., 2016).

Hudson and Ritchie (2006) point to DMOs that were able to appropriately develop film tourism development strategies, and delivered suitable managerial tools to support the increase of film locations visits. Among the most important are: rapid establishment of relationships with the film studio, support of accommodation facilities associated with filming, promotion of the site in film studios and providing a mention of the site of filming in the promotion of the film. With regard to the support of film tourism activities, DMOs can engage in the organization of film tours, festivals, creating film protocols and permits, providing assistance and incentives (Özdemir & Adan, 2014).

There are also plenty of tools to promote a destination as a film site (Hudson & Ritchie, 2006), ranging from integration of the film within commercials, dedicated websites, organizing dedicated events, through maximizing joint activities with the film studios, ensuring credits for destination, engaging the film stars in activities, delivering film and site maps, thematic walks, guides, joint promotion of film sites with hotels, restaurants, cultural sites and other facilities that appeared in a movie (Giraldi & Cesareo, 2017; Macionis, 2004; Özdemir & Adan, 2014; Teng, 2021).

Most destinations have been previously found to keep short-term focus on the facilitation of film tourism management rather than taking a strategic approach to support long-term benefits of film tourism (Heitmann, 2010). Furthermore, several authors present empirical evidence that local governments or DMOs often do not try to utilize the potential of film tourism, or fail in their efforts to do so (Hudson & Ritchie, 2006). Some refuse to invest in the promotion of film networks, and focus on more traditional activities, as for example 3 S (Abdulsamie, 2016), or devote very little effort to maximizing the impacts of film production on the destination (Hudson & Ritchie, 2006).

Outlining the variations of film tourism and the mix of motives of different nature, we come back to the initial dilemma, who is truly a film tourist (Heitmann, 2010). Despite a large body of literature on how films shape audience attitude and behavior, research on film tourists' characteristics and their broader traveling intentions when visiting a film location is still insufficient (Beeton, 2010; Fu et al., 2016). We consider estimating the relationship between the preferred type of stay and the decision to visit a film location to be a step towards filling the gap in understanding film tourism motivation. Ajzen and Fishbein (1980) define behavioral intention as individual's judgment, decision-making and willingness to invest effort in demonstrating concrete behavior. Behavioral intention can be, in the context of this study, understood as the likelihood of tourists making the decision to visit a certain film site (Wong & Lai, 2015). Several results from previous empirical studies and case studies support our research framework.

2.3 | Hypotheses

Several studies point to potential addition of film tourism to other predominant objectives of stay (Beeton, 2005; Fu et al., 2016). Buchmann et al. (2010) suggests that certain film tourists plan to visit a film site in addition to a holiday by the sea, or as part of an adventure route with many stops (Buchmann et al., 2010). But general literature suggest that the decision to visit a film site is often driven by the interest to experience something new during an active stay, during which adventure related to cinematic atmosphere of the site can be an addition to other adventurous activities (Oviedo-García et al., 2016). Therefore, we hypothesize that film tourism is connected with travel, the main goal of which is active rest and exploration, rather than relaxation, or a stay by the sea. We formulate the hypothesis, that *the preference of active rest and the "exploration" of the destination as the main aim of traveling raises the probability that the visitor will participate in film tourism activities* (H1).

Based on empirical results, the literature has not yet determined the extent to which travel agencies participate in the creation of products, services, promotions or events within film tourism (Garner, 2019). Film tourism can in case of many film sites take a naturally self-guided shape (Hudson & Ritchie, 2006), but in the case of more complex, highly popular film tours, they are often mediated by travel agencies, which offer the experience of visiting a film site as part of a more extensive product (Croy & Walker, 2003; Hudson & Ritchie, 2006). Therefore, we hypothesize that *there is an increased likelihood of visiting a film site if the stay is arranged via travel agency* (H2).

One of the significant assumptions in relation to the setting of film tourism travel is that film tourism is characterized by deseasonalization (Hudson & Ritchie, 2006). Film tourism does not require a particularly favorable climate; nor is it an activity that can only be carried out at times of the greatest tourist influx (Dominguez-Azcue et al., 2021). Therefore, we formulate the hypothesis that *film induced tourism is not seasonal and thus it will not be possible to find a relationship between the season of traveling and visiting a film site* (H3).

Film tourism can take place at a diverse geographical level from an individual's perspective—from local, through regional and national level, to a trip around the world in the footsteps of a certain film (Steinecke, 2016). Beeton (2005) suggests that due to the addition of film tourism, there can potentially be a higher chance of visiting a film location within a longer holiday, or in case of tourists with high level of travel frequency. Therefore, we add two hypotheses. First is that *the longer the average time spent in a destination, the more likely respondents are to visit a film site* (H4). We also expect that *the higher the frequency of traveling, the more likely respondents are to visit a film site* (H5).

Film tourism can be the subject of both luxury trips and budget trips (Beeton, 2001). However, when evaluating decisions to visit a destination, it is generally assumed that the travel budget positively influences the choice to participate in an additional activity or to visit an additional location during a stay (Almeida et al., 2021). We put

forward a hypothesis that *the higher the budget, the more likely respondents are to visit a film site while traveling* (H6).

In addition to investigating the relationship between travel parameters and the decision to visit a film location, we add two variables to our model that represent demographic characteristics of tourists. Several studies suggest that film tourism is not selective in terms of gender, as there are films triggering interest to visit film sites by women and men (Beeton, 2001; Macionis, 2004). Therefore, we hypothesize that *film tourism is not selective in terms of gender* (H7). Considering the factor of age, Gunlu and Lale (2015) found that visits of film festivals and sites is the domain of younger age groups. This can be related to finding that young people and students have higher travel mobility due to increased motivation and time available (Richards & Wilson, 2007). Moreover, Ng and Chan (2019) found that especially younger film site visitors want to partake in film tourism in order to develop prestige social networks. Therefore, our final hypothesis suggests that *the younger the respondents the higher the probability that they visit a film site when traveling* (H8).

3 | METHOD

3.1 | The sampling method and the sample

In order to obtain primary data, a survey was conducted to collect data on visiting film sites by tourists in the country. Thus, the research is based on primary data collected via a survey conducted in the Slovak Republic in 2019 with a total of 368 respondents. Instead of random sampling, the so called “snowball sampling” was used. Thus, the technique of data collection is utilized when it is difficult to access subjects with the target characteristics (in our case, tourists that have previous experience in film tourism). In such case, the participants of the survey recruit other subjects within their social networks, until the saturation of the survey is reached (Naderifar et al., 2017).

The questionnaire was composed of 13 semi-closed questions, to which the respondents were asked to give answers by choosing from the predefined options. The structure of the questionnaire is based on the findings of a previous study (Repánová & Moritz, 2018), which examined the offer of travel agencies in Slovakia and the experience with film tourism in two specific film sites. The questionnaire was divided into three sections. These sections collected data on: (1) basic demographic characteristics of the respondent, (2) previous experiences with film tourism, (3) motives for visiting a film site, and (4) parameters of the trip that was associated with visiting a film site and general preferences for travel. The survey was pre-tested applying the skirmishing approach (Presser et al., 2004) with a control group of 25 respondents. Pre-testing served as the basis for collection of feedback on formulation of individual questions, both in terms of content and the survey structure.

The initial round of the questionnaire distribution was done through the social networks of five DMOs (destination-management organizations) in Slovakia. The respondents of the survey were then asked to share the questionnaire within their own social networks. A

survey was stopped after a predetermined period of 2 months (October and November 2019), while taking into account requirements for reaching a balanced sample from several perspectives discussed below.

The sample can be considered balanced in terms of sex, age, and the main variable expressing whether tourist previously visited a film site. However, there is slight inequality in terms of the respondents' region of residence due to there being eight NUTS III regions, while the geographical distribution of the participants was as follows: Bratislava (the capital – 9.9%), Trnava (10.4%), Trenčín (9.7%), Nitra (28.7%), Žilina (15.6%), Banská Bystrica (11.1%), Prešov (8.2%), and Košice (6.4%). This is mainly due to the fact that the questionnaire was distributed under the university banner.

3.2 | Research framework

To test the hypotheses raised to fill described research gaps, the obtained primary data will be utilized to build a theoretical model for estimating the relationship between preferred trip parameters and the decision to visit a film site during the trip.

The description and the nature of the variables used in the analysis are summarized in Table 1. We construct a dependent variable “previous experience,” which expresses whether a given respondent has visited a film site during their trips in the past. Subsequently, we formulate independent variables that we can understand as (1) personal/individual factors—sex and age, (2) a group of variables that can be defined as prevailing trip parameters (*pref. active rest*, *pref. passive*

TABLE 1 The description of the variables used in the logit model.

The name of the variable	Description	Type
<i>previous experience</i>	The respondent's previous visit of a filming site	Binary
<i>pref. active rest*</i>	The respondent prefers active rest when traveling y/n	Binary
<i>pref. passive rest</i>	The respondent prefers passive rest when traveling y/n	Binary
<i>obj_exploration**</i>	Preference to explore when traveling y/n	Binary
<i>obj_restbythesea**</i>	Preference to rest by the sea when traveling y/n	Binary
<i>pref_travelagency</i>	The respondent prefers to travel through a travel agency y/n	Binary
<i>avg. freq. of travel</i>	Average frequency of travel (intervals)	Ordinal
<i>preferred season</i>	Prefers to travel in summer season y/n	Binary
<i>avg. length of stay</i>	Average length of stay when traveling (intervals)	Ordinal
<i>avg. budget for traveling</i>	Average budget when traveling (intervals)	Ordinal
<i>sex</i>	Man/woman	Binary
<i>age</i>	Age groups (intervals)	Ordinal

rest, *obj_exploration*, *obj_restbythesea*, and *pref_travelagency*), and (3) “preferred organizational parameters of the trip,” or habits of traveling (*avg. freq. of travel*, *preferred season*, *avg. length of stay*, and *avg. budget of traveling*). Considering the group of explanatory variables referred to as “prevailing trip parameters,” it is necessary to avoid confusion in apparent similarity or multicollinearity between the variables “*pref. active rest*” and “*obj_exploration*.” This is our specific designation of variables, while people who prefer active rest in the survey confirmed that they prefer physical activity or sports during their stay (hiking, climbing, sports games, swimming on rafts on stormy rivers, underwater tourism, safaris, etc.)—thus, activities requiring significant physical exertion. The variable “*pref. passive rest*” represents other respondents who are not looking for physically exhausting activities. The variable “*obj_restbythesea*” identifies tourists whose main holiday objective is to stay by the sea, however they can be part of a group of both active and passive tourists. In turn, the variable “*obj_exploration*” monitors the proportion of respondents who travel to discover, learn, and experience adventure, not conditioned by physically exhausting activity (visits to learn about culture, architecture, gastronomy, social artifacts, important natural sites, etc.).

The “Organization of traveling” factors express selected organizational trends of traveling, such as the “*pref_travelagency*” variable, which refers to the tendency to arrange a holiday by a travel agency, when we assume a reduced probability of visiting a film site. The variables “*avg. freq. of travel*” and “*avg. length of stay*” will control for the impact the length of stay and the volume of traveling on the probability of visiting a film site. We consider the seasonal aspects of the film tourism as not sufficiently investigated; therefore, we formulate the variable “*preferred season*,” which will express whether the respondent mostly travels in the summer or out of the summer season. The variable “*avg. budget for traveling*” is included to check for the impact of the availability of budget on participation in film tourism. The minimum criterion of one experience of filming site visit for dependent variable value 1—participated was set. To carry out the analysis, the logit model was chosen to investigate the relationship between the decision to visit a film site and explanatory factors described above. The analysis is executed using the Stata software. The probability that the tourist will visit the given filming site, thus, can be written as follows:

$$p = \frac{b\beta_0 + \beta_1 x_1 + \dots + \beta_k x_k}{b\beta_0 + \beta_1 x_1 + \dots + \beta_k x_k + 1} + \frac{1}{1 + b - (b\beta_0 + \beta_1 x_1 + \dots + \beta_k x_k)}, \quad (1)$$

where, β_k = are coefficients of the independent variables. x_k = value of the k th determinant of previous experience with film tourism.

In terms of the selected explanatory variables, the theoretical model is, as follows:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Previous experience} = & \beta_0 + \beta_1^* \text{pref. active rest} + \beta_2^* \text{pref. passive rest} \\ & + \beta_3^* \text{obj_exploration} + \beta_4^* \text{obj_restbythesea} \\ & + \beta_5^* \text{pref_travelagency} + \beta_6^* \text{avg. freq. of travel} \\ & + \beta_7^* \text{preferred season} + \beta_8^* \text{avg. length of stay} \\ & + \beta_9^* \text{avg. budget for traveling} + \beta_{10}^* \text{sex} + \beta_{11}^* \text{age} \\ & + \alpha_i + \varepsilon_{it}. \end{aligned}$$

4 | RESULTS

This part of the article presents the quantitative results of the analysis of the data obtained via the survey on the participation in film tourism activities in Slovakia. The overview of the structure of sample in terms of sex and age is provided in Table 2. The questionnaire was filled in by 187 women and 181 men. In terms of the age groups, the majority of the respondents belonged to the age categories from 15 to 55 years, however, the number of the participants in the age category above 56 years is relatively small, probably due to weaker IT skills amongst the senior citizens of Slovakia.

Due to the nature of the dissemination of the survey, up to 218 out of 368 survey respondents visited a film site, while up to 129 of them also visited a film site abroad. From this share, however, we cannot assume that the values would copy reality, given the targeting of film fans in the free distribution of the questionnaire. On the contrary, this fact allows us to obtain information about the experience with visiting film sites in the case of a sufficient number of respondents and thus map travel preferences in the field of film tourism in the remit of Slovakia. Table 3 provides information on haphazardness of visiting film sites in the sample.

TABLE 2 Structure of the sample in terms of sex and age.

Sex	Age group	Visited	Not visited	Sum
Men	15–20	19	22	41
	21–35	47	27	74
	36–55	32	29	61
	56–75		5	5
	Sum	98	83	181
Women	15–20	28	19	47
	21–35	74	45	119
	36–55	16	3	19
	56–75	2		2
	Sum	120	67	187
Total		218	150	368

TABLE 3 The influence of the film or TV series sites on the choice of the destination.

To what extent was the film or TV series sites the reason you decided to visit the destination?	No. of respondents	Proportion in %
The film/TV series site was the main reason for choosing the destination	21	10
The film/TV series site had some influence on the choice of destination	68	31
The film/TV series site had no influence on the choice of destination	129	59
Total	218	100

A relatively large proportion of the respondents visited film or TV series sites. Moreover, the findings also correspond with the mention in literature, that visiting film locations is usually not the main reason for visiting a given destination, and indeed, only 10% of the respondents considered a visit to a specific film or TV series site to be their

main motive for choosing a destination. Thus, it can be claimed that only 10% of these tourists can be regarded as specific film tourists (based on the categorization provided by Macionis, 2004). Furthermore, 31% of the visitors were driven by diverse factors or expectations to visit a given destination, while film tourism was also a part of

TABLE 4 An overview of the experience with visiting specific film or TV series locations.

Country	Place	Film/TV series/film studios	n
Slovakia	Orava Castle	Nosferatu, Král sokolů, Král Drozdí brada	107
	Bojnice castle	Fantaghirò, Šíleně smutná princezna, Pán a hvezdár	148
	Spiš castle	The Last Legion, Dragonheart, The Lion in Winter, Kull the Conqueror	69
	Čachtice castle	Bathory	3
	Tribeč mountains	Trhlina	49
	Betliar Castle	1890	3
	Martin	Perinbaba	2
Czech Rep.	Český Raj	Jak dostat tatínka do polepšovny	2
	Prague	Spider-Man: Far from Home	2
	Telč	Marie Terezie	1
	Multiple sites	Bobule	1
United States	Burbank	Warner Bros. Studios	1
	Hollywood	Multiple sites related to various films	2
	Los Angeles	Universal Studios Hollywood, Walk of Fame	6
	New York	Friends, Home Alone 2: Lost in New York, Sex and the City, The Wolf of Wall Street, The Marvelous Mrs. Maisel, The Godfather	8
	San Francisco	The Room	1
	New Haven	Gilmore Girls	1
	Chicago	Public Enemies, Drinking Buddies	1
United Kingdom	Multiple sites	Harry Potter	49
	Puzzlewood	Star Wars, Merlin	2
	Cornwall	Poldark	1
Croatia	Dubrovnik	Game of Thrones	28
	Plitvice Lakes	Winnetou	42
Hungary	Etyek	Korda studios	1
	Pilisszentlélek	Mi Kis Falunk	1
	Budapest	Nyócker!	1
Poland	Auschwitz II–Birkenau	Schindler's List	1
Italy	Montepulciano	The Twilight Saga: New Moon	1
	Rome	Roman Holiday, La Dolce Vita	1
Netherland	Amsterdam	The Hitman's Bodyguard	3
France	Paris	Moulin Rouge	1
Malta	Multiple sites	Game of Thrones	2
Thailand	Multiple sites	The Beach, James Bond	5
New Zealand	Multiple sites	The Lord of the Rings, The Hobbit	3
Tunis	Chott el Djerid	Star Wars	1
	Tamerza	The English Patient	1
China	Hong-Kong	Wong Gok hak yeh, Chung Hing sam lam, Chu dai chiu fung, Daan san nam nui	1

their motivation. These tourists can be considered to be “general” film tourists. Last but not least, 59% of the respondents indicated that they had not planned to visit film sites—it happened unintentionally during their stay. This fact also supports the assumptions that random film tourists create the largest group of film tourists.

The phenomenon of haphazardness of visit to the film sites described above is also reflected in the following evaluation of specific film sites that the survey respondents previously visited. Table 4 provides an overview of states and destinations visited by respondents in the sample, while we connect specific sites with films that inspired the respondents to choose a destination. In line with our expectations, we have identified a large volume of visits to the domestic film sites (e.g., Bojnice Castle was visited by up to 148 respondents).

At this point, however, it should be noted that due to the small area of the Slovak Republic, a relatively significant part of the cultural or natural potential of the country (especially castles, chateaux, caves and mountains) was previously used for the purposes of filming Slovak movies and, in rare cases, Czech films had been relatively frequently filmed in Slovakia as well (Hames, 2010). Therefore, due to already mentioned high proportion of random film tourists in the sample, we assume that a visit to domestic “prestigious” tourism destinations is not primarily motivated by film production, and therefore in terms of film tourism, this volume of domestic visits can be considered as random. The results showed that Slovak visitors visit European and American film-related sites the most. Respondents most often visited European space film sites in the United Kingdom (e.g., the city of London, Puzzlewood, and Cornwall), and Croatia (e.g., the famous Plitvice Lakes, and the city of Dubrovnik where *Game of Thrones* was filmed).

We have also identified 20 cases of film sites visited in the US, with New York being the most popular destination. All the above-mentioned destinations can be considered complex in terms of their tourist offer. However, it can be assumed that when a Slovak tourist travels to visit, for example, film studios in the US, it is rarely a case of a haphazard visit.

These sites have been visited despite of long distances, as iconic films and series have been made there, such as *Harry Potter* in the UK, *Game of Thrones* in Croatia, *The Wolf of Wall Street* in New York, or *Lord of the Rings* in New Zealand. Naturally, relatively high demand to visit film sites in the V4 countries was identified, especially due to their short geographical distance, such as Auschwitz II–Birkenau in Poland, Prague in the Czech Republic, or Pilisszentlélek in Hungary.

The next part of the study will be devoted to the evaluation of the prevalent objectives of travel and the prevalent organization of travel in the investigated sample. As shown in Table 5, regarding the preferred type of rest, more than 50% of the respondents prefer to combine passive and active ways of spending their holiday, however, a relatively high number of active tourists was also recorded. This is, in line with the literature, pointing out the increase in the number of tourists who spend their time on physical activity or sports during their stay (Macionis & Sparks, 2009). Moreover, it can also be seen in Table 5 that only 31% of the respondents usually use the services of travel agencies to arrange a holiday. In addition, 40% of

respondents in the sample take a trip only once per year, or less. These results can be explained by the slightly lower household incomes and nominal wages in Slovakia compared to the EU average. Regarding the preferred season, according to the survey, Slovaks are strongly oriented towards traveling in the summer (more than 70% of respondents), while almost a quarter of the respondents want to travel in the low season and only 5% in the winter.

The economic possibilities of the population are also reflected in the preferred length of stay and in the travel expenses (per 1 person). Almost half of the respondents prefer to travel for 4–7 days, however, almost 24% for 3 days or less, and up to 25% for more than 7 days. In addition, up to 45% of respondents spend only between 150- and 300-euros during a holiday, and almost 26% even less than 150 euros, while only 7.34% of respondents have the tendency to spend over 500 euros. This data, however, relates to 2019, which is the period before the start of the Covid-19 pandemic.

With regard to the prevailing objectives of travel in Table 6, up to 5.7% of the respondents identified visiting a film site as their main motive, almost 50% of the sample claimed that the main motive to take a trip was the recreational aspect, especially in the form of a stay by the sea (48%). On the other hand, up to 66.3% of the respondents prefer to travel to experience adventure and explore a site, and 33% of them consider the availability of gastronomy-related experiences as the main motive behind the choice of a destination.

Moreover, 52% of those who considered visiting film sites as the main reason for traveling to a certain destination, considered recreation to be the other reason for choosing the destination; while 76% of respondents considered exploring various attractions in a destination as the other important motive of their holiday. Only 29% of them indicated that they wanted to integrate the visit to a film site with a stay by sea. It was also observed that 95% of the respondents that planned to visit a film site were driven by gastronomical experiences, while 33% wanted to take part in sport events or activities.

5 | ANALYSIS OF DECISION TO VISIT A FILM SITE

First, we proceed with the diagnostics of the model. Having several limits, the link test (Table 7) can be used to detect specification error. The idea behind this is that if the model is properly specified, one should not be able to find any additional predictors that are statistically significant except by chance. As linear predictor value $\hat{u}$ is significant, we consider model to be properly specified. Linear predicted value squared $\hat{u}^2$ is not significant, therefore link test is not significant. This is signaling that we face no serious problem of omitting relevant variables and our link function can be considered as correctly specified (Pregibon, 1981).

Then, we test proper specification of model using Hosmer–Lemeshow test of goodness of fit (Table 8). Hosmer–Lemeshow test suggests regrouping the data by ordering on the predicted probabilities and then forming 10 nearly equal-sized groups. Because the test is not significant (Pregibon, 1981), we are satisfied with the fit of our model.

TABLE 5 Travel preferences of respondents identified by survey.

	15–20 years	21–35 years	36–55 years	56–75 years	Sum
Preferred type of rest					
Active	6.79%	16.30%	5.98%	0.00%	29.08%
Passive	3.80%	9.78%	4.62%	1.09%	19.29%
A combination of active and passive holiday	13.32%	26.36%	11.14%	0.82%	51.63%
Total	23.91%	52.45%	21.74%	1.90%	100.00%
Arranging holiday					
Independently	15.49%	38.32%	14.13%	1.09%	69.02%
Using the services of travel agencies	8.42%	14.13%	7.61%	0.82%	30.98%
Total	23.91%	52.45%	21.74%	1.90%	100.00%
Travel frequency					
Once a year or less	10.60%	16.85%	11.14%	1.09%	39.67%
Twice a year	7.88%	16.30%	6.25%	0.82%	31.25%
Several times a year	5.43%	19.29%	4.35%	0.00%	29.08%
Total	23.91%	52.45%	21.74%	1.90%	100.00%
Seasonality of travel					
In summer	18.75%	37.50%	13.59%	0.82%	70.65%
In winter	1.63%	2.17%	1.09%	0.27%	5.16%
In low season	3.53%	12.77%	7.07%	0.82%	24.18%
Total	23.91%	52.45%	21.74%	1.90%	100.00%
Average length of stay					
1 day	0.82%	1.90%	0.27%	0.00%	2.99%
2–3 days	5.43%	10.60%	7.34%	0.27%	23.64%
4–7 days	11.41%	28.53%	7.61%	0.82%	48.37%
More than 7 days	6.25%	11.41%	6.52%	0.82%	25.00%
Total	23.91%	52.45%	21.74%	1.90%	100.00%
Average costs					
Up to 150 €	7.34%	10.87%	6.79%	0.82%	25.82%
150–300 €	9.78%	27.45%	7.34%	0.27%	44.84%
300–500 €	4.62%	11.14%	5.43%	0.82%	22.01%
Over 500 €	2.17%	2.99%	2.17%	0.00%	7.34%
Total	23.91%	52.45%	21.74%	1.90%	100.00%

Below, in the Table 9, we can see the classification table for our logit model. The overall rate of correct classification is estimated to be 84.40%, with 84.40% of the normal weight group correctly classified (specificity) and 70.64% of the low weight group correctly classified (sensitivity). We use graph of ROC curve and area under it (Figure 1), to check classification performance of our model, or how much our model is capable of distinguishing between 0 and 1 classes.

When AUC is approximately 0, model is actually reciprocating the classes. It means the model is predicting negative class as a positive class and vice versa. When AUC is approximately 0.5, model has no discrimination capacity to distinguish between positive class and negative class (Bradley, 1997). The area under the curve of 0.89 in the case of our model indicates acceptable discrimination for the model.

The results of the model are presented in Table 10. The model shows that visitors who prefer active rest (physically demanding

activities and sports) are up to 2.92 times more likely to visit a film site during their stay, which is in line with the established hypothesis H1. Although on the lower level of significance, the first hypothesis was also confirmed through the positive effect of interest to explore destination (visits to learn about culture, architecture, gastronomy, social artifacts, important natural sites, etc.) during the stay. We found that if main intentions of stay are to explore, the probability of visiting a film site increases up to 2.25. Thus, we accept Hypothesis 1.

At the same time, we found strong evidence that the opposite will be truth in case of respondents that prefer passive rest. Here we need to note that we do not record a problem of multicollinearity between these two variables, as the question of preferred type of rest in the questionnaire also contained option “combined,” thus these two responses are not distributed in entire sample. In addition, this result is confirmed by the reduced probability of visiting film sites in the case

TABLE 6 Structure of respondents by main motivation to take a trip.

Main aim of the trip	No. of respondents	Proportion in %	Combined film tourism with another activity	Proportion in %
Visiting places connected with a film/TV series	50	5.70	–	–
Sport	75	20.38	7	33%
Recreation	182	49.46	11	52%
Exploration	244	66.30	16	76%
Enjoying stay by the sea	176	47.83	6	29%
Gastronomy	124	33.70	20	95%
Other	7	1.90	5	24%

TABLE 7 Results of the link test of model specification.

Number of obs.	368					
LR chi2 (2)	195.32					
Prob > chi2	0					
Pseudo R ²	0.3926					
Cooperation	Coef.	Std. err.	Z	p > z	[95% conf. Interval]	
_hat	0.9895	0.1038	9.52	0	0.7859	1.1932
_hatsq	0.0261	0.0485	0.54	0.59	−0.0689	0.1212
_cons	−0.0494	0.1723	−0.29	0.775	−0.3871	0.2885

TABLE 8 Hosmer–Lemeshow test of model compliance with observations.

Number of obs.	368
LR chi2 (16)	334
Prob > chi2	301.58
Hosmer–Lemeshow chi2 (8)	0.787
Prob > chi2	368

of respondents who are mainly looking for a classic summer vacation (sun, sand, and sea).

We found a strong negative influence of mediation of the stay in destination by a travel agency on chance to visit a film site. Therefore, we refuse the Hypothesis 2. Based on this result, we can hypothesize that film tourism takes place mainly on a self-mediated basis, especially during non-resort vacations and trips. As for the “preferred season” variable, we did not find the impact of specific season travel on film site visits, which supports the assumption raised by multiple authors that film tourism is characterized by de-seasonality. Thus, we accept Hypothesis 3. We accept also the Hypothesis 4, as we found strong evidence that with longer stay on holiday, the probability of visiting a film site is up to 2.2 times higher. However, we refuse Hypothesis 5, as no impact of frequency of travel on visiting film site was found. This could point out on irregularity of trips to film sites, while there could be an assumption that film tourists do not tend to visit film site in case of majority of stays in various destinations, which is in line with the premise that approximately 50% of film tourism is of

TABLE 9 The classification statistics and classification table.

Sensitivity	Pr(+ D)	84.40%
Specificity	Pr(– ~D)	70.67%
Positive predictive value	Pr(D +)	80.70%
Negative predictive value	Pr(~D –)	75.71%
False + rate for true ~D	Pr(+ ~D)	29.33%
False – rate for true D	Pr(– D)	15.60%
False + rate for classified +	Pr(~D +)	19.30%
False – rate for classified –	Pr(D –)	24.29%
Correctly classified		78.80%

random nature. We refuse the Hypothesis 6, as we found no impact of level of spending during holiday on this kind of experience. That means that majority of film tourism experiences appear to be not financially demanding, especially if taking place out of the metropolitan areas and expensive destinations. Thus, film tourism also appears to be of interest to low-cost travellers.

Finally, we found that to promote film tourism, gender is not an important factor in targeting potential visitors, as we found no impact of gender on decision to visit film site. Therefore, we accept Hypothesis 7. However, as suggested by other authors with an affiliation to the older age group, the probability that a tourist will take part in film tourism is significantly decreased, what shows that film tourism is still more of a domain of younger age groups, mainly up to 35 years (due to analysis of the sample). Thus, we accept Hypothesis 8.

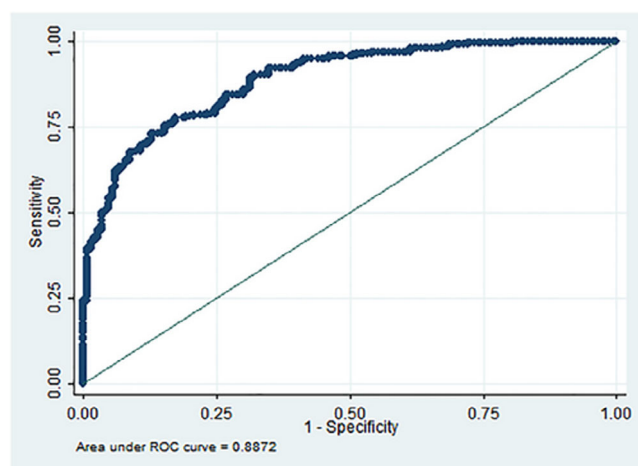


FIGURE 1 ROC curve and AUC (color figure can be viewed at [Colour figure can be viewed at wileyonlinelibrary.com])

TABLE 10 Results of the logit model.

Variable	Coef.	Log. odds
<i>pref. active rest</i>	1.0699** (0.3716)	2.9153** (1.0834)
<i>pref. passive rest</i>	−1.2096*** (0.3671)	0.2982*** (0.1095)
<i>obj_exploration</i>	0.8114* (0.3218)	2.2512* (0.7246)
<i>obj_restbythesea</i>	−1.6445*** (0.3139)	0.1931*** (0.0606)
<i>pref_travelagency</i>	−1.9471*** (0.3290)	0.1426*** (0.0469)
<i>avg. freq. of travel</i>	0.1501 (0.2993)	1.1620 (0.3479)
<i>preferred season</i>	−0.4307 (0.3360)	0.6500 (0.2184)
<i>avg. length of stay</i>	0.7804*** (0.2167)	2.1824*** (0.4729)
<i>avg. budget for traveling</i>	0.0424 (0.1713)	1.0433 (0.1788)
<i>sex</i>	0.2909 (0.3171)	1.3376 (0.4242)
<i>age</i>	−1.2263*** (0.2280)	0.2933*** (0.0669)
<i>_cons</i>	1.5822 (0.9876)	4.866015 (4.8061)
Number of obs	368	
LR chi2 (11)	195.03	
Prob > chi2	0	
Pseudo R ²	0.392	

6 | DISCUSSION

The presented results reflect on propositions (Domínguez-Azcue et al., 2021; Hahm & Wang, 2011; Kim, 2012) for better understanding the behavioral aspects of film tourism, mainly in context of film tourist segmentation and identification of decision patterns to visit film sites. As many authors have already dug deep into emotionally-driven motivation for visiting film sites (Beeton, 2005; de Araújo et al., 2018; Macionis & Sparks, 2009; Oviedo-García et al., 2016; Pan & Tsang, 2014; Raj, 2018), we addressed the question of who is truly a film tourist and what are the main fears of their traveling intentions, which remained a gap in literature. Thus, we developed a theoretical model to test the relationship between preferred trip parameters and the decision to visit a film site, and we also described trajectories of film tourism in the conditions of the V4 country.

First, it has to be mentioned that, in line with the results of Macionis (2004), only a small proportion of the tourists within the sample of the study travelled intentionally to visit a given film site. We confirm the high degree of additionally of this tourism segment, what, however, does not necessarily diminish the potential of film tourism to raise the number of visitors and strengthen the competitiveness of the destination (Domínguez-Azcue et al., 2021). In addition, we support the hypothesis that film tourism has the tendency to develop in symbiosis with other forms of tourism (Beeton, 2004; Macionis, 2004).

By estimating the parameters of our theoretical model, we tested selected, previously raised hypotheses about the segment of film tourists. Despite the results of Buchmann et al. (2010), film tourism cannot be considered additional to all other segments of tourism. In line with Oviedo-García et al. (2016) the decision to visit a film site is more often driven by an interest in experiencing something new within an active holiday, or a holiday aimed at exploring the destination. We found a negative relationship between a stay by the sea as the most preferred type of stay and taking the decision to visit a film site. In addition, we still do not know precisely to what extent travel agencies participate in the creation of products, services, promotions or events within film tourism (Garner, 2019). We found that suggestions of Hudson and Ritchie (2006) that there is a high volume of self-guided visits to film localities appear to be true. Travel agencies contribute to the development of film tourism, but mainly through products focused on the exploration of sites associated with the filming of highly popular films. In line with Beeton (2005), Hudson and Ritchie (2006), and Domínguez-Azcue et al. (2021) we confirm that film tourism does not require a particularly favourable climate; nor is it highly tied to a specific season. Thus, we can consider film tourism to be characterised by de-seasonalisation, with the exception of sites that cannot be, for example, visited in winter for practical reasons.

Then, we were based on the assumptions of Steinecke (2016) that film tourism can take place at a diverse geographical level from local, through regional and national level, to a trip around the world in the footsteps of a given film. In line with Beeton (2005), we found that the length of stay raises the chance to visit a film location, but

we found no impact of frequency of travel on whether the respondent visited a film site. We did not prove the general expectations (Almeida et al., 2021) that the probability of visiting a film site increases with budget. In accordance with Beeton (2001), it is rather true that film tourism can be the subject of both luxury trips and budget trips. With relation to results for the demographic characteristics of the respondents, in line with the results of Beeton (2001), Macionis (2004), and Ng and Chan (2019), the findings also suggest to focus the tools of destination promotion on younger age groups, mainly up to 35 years, as film tourism appears to be mainly a matter of younger age categories. We did not find film tourism to be selective in terms of gender.

In addition, it seems that film tourism appears to be an attractive branch of tourism also within the Central Eastern Europe countries (Göttlichová & Šula, 2020; Kotíková, 2013). The results of the survey revealed that even in smaller countries of the former post-socialist bloc, such as Slovakia, film tourism is a dynamically developing segment of creative tourism. It was found that domestic film tourism, often considered to be an overlooked topic in film tourism literature (Meng & Tung, 2016), represents the largest share of visits to film sites in the sample. Specific film tourists in the sample mainly visited, amongst other countries, destinations in Europe (mostly UK, Croatia, and other V4 countries), but also very visible and massively promoted locations within other parts of the world. Film tourism can also be a primary pull factor in the case of destinations, in which the film site can be considered as the most valuable “potential” for development of tourism and, thus, support destinations in rural benefiting otherwise mainly from availability of natural and cultural geographical capital (Nizioł, 2015).

7 | IMPLICATIONS AND FURTHER RESEARCH

7.1 | Theoretical implications

From a theoretical standpoint, this study confirms the assumptions of considerable heterogeneity of motives for visiting film locations and different drivers of visiting a film location in the case of specific, general, and random film tourists. The study expands the knowledge about the behavioral aspects of film tourism by identifying the main parameters of film tourists' stays and, thus, provides some answers to the question of who is truly a film tourist. Within the parameter estimates of our theoretical model, we did not differentiate between specific and random film tourists, to improve the comprehensive understanding of film tourists as an integrated target group.

Film sites are more frequently visited by tourists of younger age, while no patterns of selectivity have been identified in terms of gender. Also due to the volume of random visits, film tourism often takes place during longer trips, and can be described as de-seasonal. Especially in the case of specific tourists, the mediation of film tours plays an important role, but in general, the majority of film tourism is self-guided. We found no relationship between budget and the decisions to visit the film location.

7.2 | Managerial implications

Regarding the managerial implications, the study leads to interesting insights into the preferred trip parameters of film tourists, while these results can be utilized by destination management in its efforts to capitalize on film tourism as a promotional tool to attract visitors. A number of studies have brought knowledge on how DMOs, in cooperation with film commissions and other key stakeholders, should ensure a suggestive image of attractions connected with filming in connection with proper promotional campaigns (Araújo Vila et al., 2021; Macionis, 2004; Teng, 2021). This study complements this knowledge by providing recommendations in the area of appropriate targeting of the segment of film tourists.

Film tourism was also in conditions of this study found to be relatively highly haphazard, while film-related activities can be a suitable additional tool for the promotion of key attractions. This applies (in the conditions of smaller countries of Central-Eastern Europe) also in the case of domestic cinematography or serial production. We recommend focusing on the integration of visits to film locations into complex products consisting of a set of adventure experiences, or using tools that stimulate self-guided visits (e.g., film maps, self-guided film routes, and guide apps). Not ignoring the features of the specifics of film audience in the case of individual films or series, it is true that among specific film tourists (Macionis, 2004) adventurers and active tourists in lower age categories dominate, which must be taken into account when planning the promotion. Campaigns based on the use of social networks and similar types of digital media should not be avoided.

7.3 | Limitations and further research

There are multiple limitations that did not allow to fully develop the potential of the research framework. First, the study is based on cross-sectional data with a limited number of respondents, which do not allow longitudinal monitoring of the influence of preferred parameters of stay on visits to film sites in the case of concrete stays. Our data is also influenced by the collection method, thus by the use of snowball sampling, which leads to bias in the form of an increased proportion of respondents in the sample who visited film sites. In addition, the data was gathered within only one country, thus results can be interpreted only with regard to the given country or equivalent conditions elsewhere. Research design deficiencies are also related to the data, especially focus on visit of film site at any time during life within the explained variable formulation. Considering the volume of available data, the study also could not explain changes in the structure of stays in the case of visits to film sites by specific, general, and random film tourists.

From the results of the study, multiple implications for further research arise. First, it is desirable to continue researching film tourists as a segment and the specific characteristics and expectations of specific, general, and random film tourists. Current literature describes the structure of film tourism products and services, and the degree of integration of these products and services within broader integrated products, only within a few case studies. The degree of complementarity or

additionality of film tourism to other branches of tourism needs to be explained more precisely. Moreover, there are no deductive empirical studies clarifying the impact of specific attributes of management and marketing strategies in destination management on the growth in visits to film locations, or the growth of income from film tourism activities.

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CONFLICT OF INTEREST STATEMENT

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

Primary data are available for public at: <https://bit.ly/3hJKGJg>.

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SUPPORTING INFORMATION

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